spread of political populism and the crisis of liberalism arising from the opposition to liberal values. In recent decades, disruptive political, social and technological change has created a sense of loss and bewilderment for many. From this void stem populism, authoritarianism and nationalism, each of which provide the promise of a return to a golden age which appears precious given current uncertainties. Change has created its own backlash as surely as it had in past centuries.

Zakaria says his fear is that the roots of democracy in many nations may be shallower than is accepted and a US retreat may erode them further

In brief, then, the very success of the liberal revolution in the past half century created a reaction that has expressed itself as a crisis in global liberalism animated by the mainstreaming of identity politics, strong authoritarian-style politics amidst strident demands to roll back globalisation, etc. 'Trumpism' as a phenomenon seems evident and almost inevitable after two terms of Barack Obama as president, the loss of US manufacturing, rising unemployment, etc.

To Zakaria, this blowback against liberalism and modernity also has a wider dimension: it reflects and follows from the decline of the US as a global power hegemon. He writes, "As American dominance started to erode, openness and liberalism came under pressure." When asked during our conversation whether this was not an unduly US-centric perspective, Zakaria said that his fear was that roots of democracy in many countries may be shallower than is generally accepted and a US retreat may erode them further.

What are Zakaria's prescriptions? Surprisingly mild on the surface but requiring a reorientation of mindsets: strengthen communities, invest in multiculturalism, construct an immigration policy that is robust and rule-based, don't force change down people's throats or seek to expedite its pace. Somewhat surprisingly, Zakaria also invokes Singapore's Lee Kuan Yew as a template of being a bulwark for liberalism today because he transformed a largely ethnic Chinese society into a genuinely multicultural Singapore and abhorred playing politics with identity. That Singapore's, admittedly mild, authoritarianism can be a model for the West is a measure of just how embattled liberals in the United States and Europe may be feeling. This book, brimming with ideas and connections, provides insights into that malaise. ■

–The author is a former Indian ambassador

ated with Islamic culture, this chapter, among others, shows us just how wrong that assumption is. "I found myself on a self-appointed crusade to excavate how diverse the concerns of the Urdu poet have been and how Urdu poetry is NOT poetry by Muslims for Muslims about Muslims...," she writes in the 'Introduction'.

Ram, for instance, is described as "knowledge incarnate" and "a mirror of love and affection". Gautam Buddha, Jalil writes, "is almost always invoked when the Urdu poet wishes to stress the antiquity of this ancient land". Besides the cross-cultural and cross-religious impulses, Urdu poetry has something to say about nearly everything. From major historical events like the Jallianwala Bagh massacre and the dawn of independence to metaphysical musings on women and home, to something as banal as paan. Revolutionary fervour seeps into much of this poetry, and there is often a clear link with people's movements. Taken together, the essays offer a glimpse into the many modes and moods of the Urdu poet.

Jalil, a writer, translator, critic and editor, has written extensively on literary figures, poetry and Urdu writing. This book lands in an atmosphere of communalism, as she reflects on in her 'Introduction'. But instead of dwelling on the fissures in Indian society, it is meant to be a hope-driven palliative, an antidote to reality through the romance of the written word.

Jalil's book clusters essays into four sections: 'Politics', 'People', 'Passions' and 'Places'. Some were written over the years and published elsewhere. Her essays are strongest in the moments when her personal tastes and experiences creep in, or when she digresses into the lives of the poets she quotes. But there are moments when the collection feels too long; eager to cover too much ground, with some essays reduced to a collection of excerpts from poems. ■

–Bhavya Dore



LOVE IN THE TIME OF HATE
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